Lesson 01 material: Introduction to Academic Writing

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Unit 1 Introduction to Academic Writing

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Unit 1 Introduction to Academic Writing

Learning Objectives

1. To understand what academic writing is
2. To learn the characteristics of academic writing and ways to achieve them
3. To address some common misconceptions about writing

I. Warm – Up

(Picture: computer keyboard, notebook, ear buds, and coffee)

computer keyboard, notebook, ear buds, and coffee

Discuss in groups:

1. Do you like writing in your native language? What do you usually write about?
2. How do you like writing in English? When do you write in English?
3. What makes good writing in your native language? In English?
4. What is your most unforgettable writing experience in either language?
5. What are the purposes of writing?
6. What areas of English writing are easy for you? What areas are challenging?
7. What expectations do you have for this course?
8. What do you think academic writing is?

II. Definition of Academic Writing

What is writing for? As you have just discussed, the simplest answer is to communicate meaning.

People write for different purposes. For example,

- Some of them write to inform, as in news stories and technical manuals[1].
- Some write to entertain[2], as in fictions and movie scripts.
- In daily life, people may scribble[3] a short reminder note, compose a festive party invitation, or craft a well-versed[4] love letter.
- In work, meeting memos[5] and business reports are very common.
- In colleges and universities, students write paragraphs, essays, research papers, lab reports, and many others. These forms of writing are called academic writing – a formal, nonfictional written

piece of work for learning, teaching, and researching.

It is the last type – academic writing – that this course is introducing and focusing on. At this intermediate level, you will be learning the basic styles and uses as well as practicing editing skills associated with academic writing to be ready for higher-level compositions[6] in colleges and universities.

III. Characteristics of Academic Writing

All types of writing share many aspects in common. However, each type has its own characteristics. Academic writing is characterized by the following:

1. Logical and direct

Academic writing in English uses a very linear organizational style. This means that the writers explain their information in a straightforward way, like a vertical line – the main idea first, followed by supporting ideas to explain the main idea, and a conclusion that signals the completion of the explanation.

Main idea

⇓

Supporting ideas

⇓

Conclusion

Unlike the approaches[7] in some other countries, the American style requires the students to state their focus early in their writing, without “hiding” the points or “circulating” hints till the end of writing.

2. Formal

Formal, standard English is expected. This requires a good understanding of formal grammar and usage. Colloquial[8] and spoken English should not be used.

3. Clear

Writing clearly is extremely important as the purpose of writing is not only to clarify your own thoughts but also to communicate them for others to understand. To achieve this, you should not translate from your native language and should always proofread[9] your writing for accuracy.

4. Concise

Being concise means not repeating the same words and ideas unnecessarily. Sometimes, repetition is important to emphasize a point, but most often needless duplications[10] of the same ideas may make your writing redundant[11] and inefficient.

Writing is a process. Almost no one can produce perfect writing on the first try; in fact, there is no such thing as perfect writing. Good writing takes time and repeated revisions[12]. Most importantly, it takes patience and continuous efforts to achieve the characteristics explained above.

IV. Ten Most Common Misconceptions about Writing

(Picture: wrong way traffic sign)

wrong way traffic sign

The following ten misconceptions[13] are very common among ESL students of all levels. Read each statement first and think/discuss whether you feel the same way. Then click to read explanations and suggestions.

EXERCISE

1. I translate sophisticated vocabulary and complex sentences from my native language to English so that my English writing looks much better.: Writing well is never easy, even for native speakers of English. If you are a beginning level ESL student, translating from your first language is very natural, but relying on translation into intermediate and advanced levels will affect your learning negatively. Imagine how you would handle a 30-page research paper or a 10-page business report a few years later? You would probably not have the time transferring ideas between two languages, but more importantly, your readers would most likely not be able to understand your ideas completely because no two languages could be translated word for word without losing meaning and clarity in the process. Therefore, keeping translating from your native language will NOT make your English writing better. On the contrary, the opposite is true. For the same reason, heavy reliance on a bilingual dictionary is not a good idea, either. Learning to form, process, and express ideas in English takes time, but it is a skill that can be trained, developed, and acquired. Now is a good time to change the habit of translating. The longer you wait, the harder it will be to break this habit. When you write in English, start with the vocabulary and sentence structure you know no matter how simplistic they may sound. Gradually you will build your skills in thinking and writing in English. Be patient with yourself and learn to accept imperfections. Over time, you will surely see the improvement. For the readers, it is much more acceptable to have a simple but comprehensible piece of writing than the one that they cannot understand well. For ideas and practice in how to think and write in English, please refer to Appendix A Non-Stop Non-Translation (NSNT) Free Writing with Additional Weekly Prompts. (Open Appendix A here.)
2. I do not know what to write. I worry about my assignments a lot, and then I google to get some ideas.: Sudden moments of inspiration may occasionally occur, but you cannot count on them when your writing assignment is due the next day. Instead, just start writing! Once you start jotting down your thoughts, more will follow. The key is to get started. It is perfectly fine if the ideas in the beginning do not seem good enough. Good writing takes time, so do not wait till the last minute. One way to stay on track is to schedule backwards, starting from the due date and allowing enough time for editing, revising, drafting, outlining, and brainstorming. For more information and practice on the writing process, please refer to Unit 2 The Writing Process. (Open Unit 2 here.). Occasional googling is fine, but if you rely on the Internet information for an assignment, you will experience many potential disadvantages: You will easily fall into the temptation of plagiarism - copying other people's work and taking it as your own. Your thinking will be limited by what you read. Your writing will not show your unique, interesting perspective. You will not be improving your skills steadily throughout the semester. You will not be able to do well in-class writing exams.

3. The more general the topic is, the easier it is to write.: In a way, it is true. You may have a lot of information about general topics like vacations and holidays. However, good writing is less about how “broadly” you can write about a topic but more about how “deeply” you can write about it. Therefore, narrow down a general topic to find a unique angle you can write from. There should always be a clear, sharp focus on your writing. When you pick a topic, ask yourself first: How much more do I know about this topic than most of my classmates? What unique experiences and/or knowledge do I have about this topic? How will my readers gain a new level of understanding about this topic or about me through my writing? For example, it is fine to write a wonderful vacation (happy family time, beautiful beaches, good food, etc.), but most people have similar experiences. Therefore, if you want to stay on this topic, try a different way and write about unusual vacation experiences, such as an interesting conversation with a hotel staff member, or an unexpected scenery reminding you of your childhood. Here is another example. It is a common to write about the best inventions: cell phones, computers, airplanes... These are good topics if you are able to make your writing interesting and insightful with your experiences or knowledge. However, it is more fun to write and read if you select a topic that most people do not think about, like hair color or garbage disposal. Of course, you need to have used those products in order to write well. For details about how to choose a topic, please refer to Unit 2 The Writing Process. (Open Unit 2 here.)
4. I like to start writing right away. Prewriting is a waste of time.: Plunging into drafting seems like a time saving way to finish a writing assignment, but the result is not ideal in most cases. Prewriting activities like brainstorming can lead to many surprising discoveries you are often unconscious of. Another essential step of prewriting is outlining. Without an outline, some common problems will occur, for instance, the mismatch of the main idea and the supporting ideas, lack of sufficient details, overlapping details, and the illogical order of information. With an outline, you can catch and fix those problems more easily before devoting your efforts to the draft of your paragraph. Prewriting is a good investment of your time. For details about prewriting, please refer to Unit 2 The Writing Process. (Open Unit 2 here.)
5. It is a good idea to keep adding new things while I am writing.: It is great to have new ideas! In order to stay on your topic, do this: As soon as you have a new thought, insert it in your outline to see if it fits. If it does, include it in your writing. If it does not, ignore it. The following questions will help you decide: Does it support the main idea? Is this a major supporting idea or a specific detail? Where should it go in my writing? Has something similar already been included?
6. ESL tutoring is for students who are not doing well in the course.: This statement is far from the truth. Tutoring is for every student. In fact, students who are doing very well use this free service more often than others, which is one of the main reasons for their continued success. Every student has strong and weak areas in writing, and there is always a way to write better. At Harper College, free ESL tutoring is offered by experienced teachers. They can address your individual issues in writing. Tutoring is highly recommended to all students and is well worth your time.
7. My professor will correct every error in my writing.: While many professors may point out or correct most errors in the first writing assignment, they often do not do so in the later assignments. One of the goals is to train you to become independent writers; therefore, professors usually mark the types of errors, for example, fragment and wrong verb tense. They expect you to learn to correct the errors by yourself. As the semester goes on, you will become more and more comfortable

identifying and fixing mistakes on your own. It is important to communicate with your professor regularly with any questions you have. You will be happy to realize that you are becoming more and more independent in writing. That is a very powerful feeling to have!

8. My family and friends are the best people to help me improve my writing.: Your professors and ESL tutors are the best people to help you because they can explain what, how, and why. Of course, your family and friends can provide quick help when you need it. However, most of them do not usually know the specific requirements of your assignment, nor are they trained in explaining the rules and usage to you. While they have the best intention, they sometimes do the assignment for you without helping you understand why it should be done this way. If you often rely on the help of your family or friends, one of the consequences is that you lose the benefit of learning from your mistakes and thus fail to improve your writing skills as expected in the course. Besides, you may not do well in in-class writing exams. Furthermore, you will not be prepared for your future college level courses. Your writing skill is for you to "own", a skill that you will need and value for a lifetime.
9. I will just focus on reading and writing courses in order to go to English 101. Grammar is not important.: At Harper College, a certain grade in advanced ESL reading and writing courses is required to progress to English 101, for such a grade indicates your readiness for this first college level composition class. A lot of writing is involved in these advanced reading and writing courses, and without a good command of grammar, it can be very challenging to complete them successfully. As explained earlier in this unit, academic writing requires formal and standard English, which is extensively explained and practiced in grammar classes. Although a good mastery of grammar does not necessarily translate to perfect writing, it is the foundation of good writing in ESL and college level courses.
10. Since it is a writing class, I do not need to read regularly.: It is common to run out of fresh ideas or not to understand sophisticated vocabulary and sentence structure. One solution is to read more. Good writers are almost always good readers. Reading provides good material – research findings, literary characters, news events… - to make your writing detailed and interesting. Besides, critical reading produces critical thinkers who can often address a topic in depth and with a unique perspective.

V. Unit Review Practice

Exercise: Discuss the following topics in groups. Then choose one of them to write a paragraph.

1. What is academic writing? What are the characteristics of academic writing?
2. What has been your best writing experience? The most challenging writing experience?
3. The ten common misconceptions are explained in this unit. What are the ones that apply to you? What advice will be the most helpful to you?

EXERCISE

Writing task: You may write in your notebook or in the box below. (Warning: Once you leave this page, you will lose what you have written in the box.) .

NSNT Practice

(Picture: a pen writing in a notebook)

a pen writing in a notebook

Study **Appendix A NSNT Free Writing Approach** *(Open Appendix A here.)*. Then choose two topics from the Week 1 additional prompts[14] and practice NSNT free writing. Remember not to translate from your native language and not to stop writing once you start.

EXERCISE

Writing task: You may write in your notebook or in the box below. (Warning: Once you leave this page, you will lose what you have written in the box.) .

Vocabulary Review

(Picture: a page in a dictionary)

a page in a dictionary

The words here have appeared in this unit. The best way to learn them is to guess the meaning of each word from the context. Then hover your computer mouse over the number beside each word to check its meaning and part of speech. These words are also listed in the footnote area at the end of each unit.

Here, you can use the flashcards below to review these words.

EXERCISE

- **scribble**: verb, write quickly and informally
- **manual**: noun, a small book of instructions
- **approach**: noun, a way of thinking about and doing things
- **entertain**: verb, provide music, stories, etc. for people to enjoy
- **well-versed**: adjective, with beautiful language use
- **memo**: noun, a short message or report
- **composition**: noun, a piece of writing such as an essay for a college course
- **colloquial**: adjective, informal
- **proofread**: verb, read and check for mistakes
- **duplication**: noun, a copy, a repetition
- **redundant**: adjective, wordy, repetitive, unnecessarily
- **revision**: noun, a new copy showing improvement
- **misconception**: noun, a wrong idea
- **prompt**: noun, a topic for writing

Summary

1. Academic writing is what students write for their classes in colleges and universities.
2. Academic writing is logical, direct, formal, clear, and concise.
3. To improve writing skills, it is important to:
   - Try not to translate from your native language.
   - Do not rely on the information on the Internet.

- Explore your topic by brainstorming and then organize your ideas by outlining.
- Narrow down a general topic to a more specific one.
- Get help from your professor and ESL tutors.
- Be proactive in contacting your professor regarding errors in your writing.
- Do not rely too much on the help of your family and friends.
- Study grammar.
- Read as much as you can.

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- a page in a dictionary © Pixabay

1. manual: noun, a small book of instructions ↲
2. entertain: verb, provide music, stories, etc. for people to enjoy ↲
3. scribble: verb, write quickly and informally ↲
4. well-versed: adjective, with beautiful language use ↲
5. memo: noun, a short message or report ↲
6. composition: noun, a piece of writing such as an essay for a college course ↲
7. approach: noun, a way of thinking about things and doing things ↲
8. colloquial: adjective, informal ↲
9. proofread: verb, read and check for mistakes ↲
10. duplication: noun, a copy, a repetition ↲
11. redundant: adjective, wordy, repetitive unnecessarily ↲
12. revision: noun, a new copy showing improvement ↲
13. misconception: noun, a wrong idea ↲
14. prompt: noun, a topic for writing ↲

Appendix A Non-Stop Non-Translation (NSNT) Free Writing with Additional Weekly Prompts

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Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://harpercollege.pressbooks.pub/academic-writing-skills/chapter/appendix-a-non-stop-non-translation-nsnt-free-writing-with-additional-prompts/
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Appendix A Non-Stop Non-Translation (NSNT) Free Writing with Additional Weekly Prompts

(Picture: a pen writing in a notebook)

a pen writing in a notebook

I. Non-Stop Non-Translation (NSNT) Free Writing

- Do you often translate from your native language to English when you think, write, and speak?
- Do you find it hard to write your paragraphs and essays without translating from your native language?
- Have you had challenges in making other people understand you?

If your answer to any of these three questions is a yes, you may want to learn to think and write in English through **the Non-Stop Non-Translation (NSNT) free writing approach**. It is one of the most effective ways to **practice thinking and writing without translating**. Free writing may serve different purposes, such as generating ideas and expressing viewpoints. However, in this NSNT approach, the goal is to help you think and write in English. As you gradually train yourself not to rely on your native language in your thinking, you will be able to speak, read, AND write more naturally in just English.

II. Importance of Thinking in English While Writing

1. As you learned from Unit 1 Introduction to Academic Writing, (*Open Unit 1 here.*) in the very beginning of this course, the purpose of writing is to communicate your ideas accurately and effectively. As no two languages are exactly the same, your meaning usually gets lost or misinterpreted to some degree during direct translation from one language to the other. Consequently, your writing may confuse the readers or cause misunderstanding.

2.. When you formulate ideas in your native language and then translate them into English, the process takes longer than when you deal with only one language. As you prepare for your academic study in the U.S., you will be required to read and write a lot. You will not have enough time to complete them within the time frame set by your professors if you have to translate most of the times.

3. Old habits die hard. This saying means that it is hard to break an old habit. The longer you rely on translating, the harder it will be to quit the habit. At this intermediate level of English, you are in a good position to START switching the language in which you normally think when you are writing in English: from your native language to English.

III. Steps in NSNT Free Writing

1. Prepare a notebook just for this practice. If you choose to type, set up a special folder or file on your computer. Record the date. You need to write or type in English ***nonstop*** so that you will have *no time translating* from your native language to English. Try three minutes, four times a week, and then gradually increase the duration and frequency as you feel more comfortable. Set your timer if needed.
2. You may decide on your own topic or choose one of the topics provided to get started. If you start rambling or end up writing something totally different, it is OK! The most important is that there is only *one language – English* – in your mind.
3. If you run out of ideas, just keep writing. You may write "Oh, I don't know what more to write. Need ideas… 2 more minutes…" If you are really stuck, just write "Monday, Tuesday…", or "January, February …", or even "one, two, three…" ***Do not let the tip of your pen leave your notebook page, or do not stop typing.***
4. Do not worry about grammar and spelling. Do not stop to check your dictionary. The purpose is not to produce perfect writing, but to think in English. If you want to correct mistakes, do so after you complete the NSNT practice for that day.

Example:

1/15/2022

My first time to write like this. teacher said no stopping, it's hard, but I'll try. The first topic my feelings about this new semester. I feel writing is hard, but important. I want to take college classes after ESL. I want to practice good writing. What else? No stop now, keep writing. One, two, three, four, five, Oh, yes, writing. I took writing II last semester, I did well. I want to learn more and take this class. what else to write? no stopping, no translate, it's hard, no native language, keep writing, writing. My language different from english, no translate is hard. Many mistakes but teacher said don't worry about spelling, grammar, just keep writing. I feel uncomfortable with mistakes. Teacher say no stopping and no translate most important.

The above is a very typical example in the first few days or even weeks of your NSNT practice, but soon you will feel much more comfortable and have more ideas to write about, all in English!

It takes time to acquire this new skill, but if you keep practicing, you will be well on your way to thinking and writing in English. It may take some students a semester or even a year or more, so do not feel discouraged if you do not see progress right away.

Just like working out, it takes consistent efforts to strengthen muscles.

(Picture: three people lifting barbells)

three people lifting barbells

IV. Weekly Writing Prompts

To get you started, here are some suggested topics for each week of the semester. You can modify them as you wish.

EXERCISE

Week 1 Click here for additional writing prompts: How do you feel about this first week of the semester? What are your plans for this semester? How are you going to study differently this semester from how you studied in the past? What is your classroom like? Describe it. If you are taking this course online, describe your surroundings (your house, room…). What does “academic honesty” mean to you? As you study Unit 1 Introduction to Academic Writing, which of the ten misconceptions is the most relevant to you? How are you going to improve in that area? What are your expectations of this course? (Spring Semester) Do you have a New Year’s resolution? If yes, describe it. If no, why not? (Spring semester) What was an interesting event during your winter break? Describe it. (Fall semester) What was an interesting event in summer? Describe it.

Week 2 Click here for additional writing prompts: How do you feel about this second week of the semester? Do you feel more comfortable now than last week? Why or why not? Have you met some old friends or classmates this semester? What have you talked about? Have you made some new friends in the past two weeks? How did you meet each other? Have you tried the free ESL tutoring this week? If yes, what did you work on? If not, why not? Have you visited the college library since the beginning of the semester? If so, how do you like it and why? Have you read some books lately? Do you have a favorite book? Describe it. Do you have a favorite author? Describe him or her. (Spring semester) Martin Luther King Jr. Birthday is celebrated in the U.S. in January every year. What do you know about Martin Luther King Jr. and the American Civil Rights Movement? (Fall semester) Labor Day falls on the first Monday in September each year. What do you know about Labor Day in the U.S.? Do you have Labor Day in your country? How do you celebrate it? Martin Luther King Jr Birthday and Labor Day both started to fight for human rights though they were in two very different areas. What do human rights mean to you?

Week 3 Click here for additional writing prompts: Have you had a major assignment in one of your courses? Describe it. Have you had a major test in one of your courses? How did you do? Describe it. Should schools eliminate tests? Why or why not? Do tests encourage students to study harder? Why or why not? Have you had a very positive or negative experience with tests? Describe your experience. Did you try the NSNT free writing last week? This week? How do you feel about it? There are many student clubs on campus. Are you part of at least one of them? If yes, describe the club. If not, what club would you like to join and why? In what ways can college students train their leadership skills?

Week 4 Click here for additional writing prompts: What is dating like in your country? Do you believe in love at first sight? Why or why not? What are the advantages and disadvantages of Internet dating? Do you think arranged marriage is a good idea? Why or why not? What do you think are the most important factors to make a marriage strong and healthy? What do you think should be the minimum age for marriage? Why do you think so? Many people say that love is blind. How do you understand this saying? Do you believe it? What are the advantages and disadvantages of being single? What is your definition of a home? (Spring semester) Do you have Valentine’s Day or a similar day in your country? If so, describe it.

Week 5 Click here for additional writing prompts: What are some of the ways people from different cultures can learn from each other? What does the word “respect” mean to you? What is one aspect of culture from another country that you appreciate? Describe it. What is one of the most important aspects of your native culture that you would like to introduce to your classmates? What is one of the

values from your native country that other people may misunderstand? Explain the reasons. Was there a time when you felt especially respected or disrespected? Describe it. Was there a time when an aspect of your native culture was honored in America? Describe it. Why do you think prejudice exists in the world? What are two of the ways people can try to overcome prejudice in their daily life? What can professors and students do to create a more positive and respectful learning environment on campus?

Week 6 Click here for additional writing prompts: What is the most important holiday in your native country? Describe it. How do you celebrate it now that you are in the U.S.? What is one area about your culture that you are particularly proud of? Describe it. If you could create a holiday, what would it be and why? What is the most significant holiday gift you have received? Describe it. In most countries, people like to visit families and relatives during holidays. Why do you think this tradition is important? What kinds of gifts are acceptable and what kinds are unacceptable in your native country? (Spring semester) President's Day is celebrated in the U.S. in February. What do you know about any of the American presidents? Describe him. Is there a leader from your native country that you admire? Describe him or her.

Week 7 Click here for additional writing prompts: What is one of the most significant differences between education in the U.S. and education in your native country? Is it a good idea for smart children to skip grades? Why or why not? (For example, after finishing Grade 3, a child skips Grade 4 and goes directly to Grade 5.) What has been your most interesting educational experience? Describe it. Has your educational goal changed recently? Explain why or why not. Many people believe that education is the best gift parents can give to their children. Do you agree? Why or why not? Should college students spend the most of their energy studying? Explain your reasons. Should a college education be available to all people for free? Explain your reasons. Should all college students be required to take at least one online course? Why or why not?

Week 8 Click here for additional writing prompts: Textbooks in the U.S. are very expensive. So far, how do you like this free textbook (Building Academic Writing Skills)? Why do you feel this way? What do you like about it? What suggestions do you have to make the book better? What is one of the important aspects of writing you have learned this semester? Explain your view. What is considered good writing? Why do you think so? How do you view yourself as a writer? Why do you think so? What is one of the important aspects of learning for you this semester (any class)? Describe it. You may have had at least one in-class timed writing exam. How did you feel about it? What area of study do you need to improve? What will you do to improve it in the second half of the semester? What resources have you used at Harper so far (library, tutoring, Language Lab, etc.)? In what ways do they help you?

Week 9 Click here for additional writing prompts: What is the meaning of your name? Is it a typical name in your culture? Does it have a clear connection to your personal identity? In the U.S., many people like to call each other by the first name. In your native culture, how do you call your grandparents, parents, uncles and aunts, brothers and sisters, cousins, professors, neighbors, and friends? What are the ways to make American friends? What are effective ways to make a good first impression when meeting new people? Is it better to have lots of friends or just one or two good friends? Why? Is it possible to have cross-generational friends? (for example, an 18-year-old and a 70-year-old become good friends.) Many people like to make many "Facebook friends". If you use any social media, how many friends do you have there? How many of them do you keep in touch? Descirbe

what you often discuss with them. Have you been to a party and later regretted going? If so, describe it. What are your hobbies? Describe them. What is one sport that you like to watch but have not played. Explain why you have not played it.

Week 10 Click here for additional writing prompts: What is your most memorable travel experience? Describe it. If you could take just one person to travel around the world for a year, whom would you take and why? Imagine you are going on a two-week vacation out of the state by yourself without your cell phone. What challenges would you encounter? How would you solve them? What is your favorite season? Describe it. Chicago is known for its cold winters. Describe how you spent your first winter in Chicago. If you have not spent a winter in Chicago, image what it would be like and describe it. (Spring semester) What is your plan for Spring Break? (Spring semester) What does “spring” mean to you? (Spring semester) What are some interesting spring time activities in your native country? Describe them. (Fall semester) What does “fall” mean to you? (Fall semester) What are some interesting fall activities in your native country? Describe them.

Week 11 Click here for additional writing prompts: Do mothers and fathers take care of their children in different ways? Describe the similarities and differences. What is the best advice you have received from your parents? Explain it. Is it common to take children to a parent's workplace in your native country? What is the most important: being smart, being healthy, or being good-looking? Why? What is the new trend in fashion these days? Do you consider yourself a fashion-conscious person? Some people believe that appearance is very important, and some others believe that a person’s inner self (character, personality, etc.) is more important? What do you think and why? (Spring semester) How did you spend your Spring Break? Which part was the best? Which part was the worst? (Fall semester) Americans celebrate Halloween on October 31. How do you feel about Halloween? Are you going to celebrate it this year? Why or why not?

Week 12 Click here for additional writing prompts: Look at yourself in the mirror, what three words come to your mind to describe how you look? Explain them. If you could change one thing about yourself, what would it be and why? If you could change one thing about one of your family members, who would it be, what the change would it be, and why? If you could change one thing about this class, what would it be and why? If you could change one thing about your college, what would it be and why? If you could change one thing about your native country, what would it be and why? If you could change one thing about the U.S., what would it be and why? If you could change one thing about the world, what would it be and why?

Week 13 Click here for additional writing prompts: What is your favorite social media site? Why is it your favorite? What are the benefits of social media? Describe them. What are the disadvantages of social media? Describe them. Should parents supervise their teenage children’s the use of social media? Why or why not? What would you do to entertain your family or friends without spending any money? (Fall semester) Americans celebrate Veterans Day in November. What part of the American history do you find the most fascinating? Describe it. What part of the history of your native country do you think the most important? Describe it. If you could live the life of a person in history, whom would you choose? Why would you choose that person?

Week 14 Click here for additional writing prompts: Thanksgiving Day is coming. What are you most thankful for? Why do you feel this way? What have you been eating for meals and snacks in the past

two days? Is your diet healthy? Why or why not? What are the ways you can improve your diet? What is your favorite holiday food in your native country? In the U.S.? Describe them. What are the ways families and friends can strengthen their relationships? What are the advantages and disadvantages of moving away from the parents' home? (Fall semester) Thanksgiving Day is near. What are you plans for the holiday? (Fall semester) Is there a similar holiday in your native country? How do people celebrate it there?

Week 15 Click here for additional writing prompts: Do you think the minimum driving age (currently sixteen in the U.S.) should be raised or lowered? Why? If you could add one new rule for new drivers, what would it be and why? Do you think the minimum drinking age (currently twenty-one in the U.S.) should be raised or lowered? Why? Should adults drink alcohol in front of children under eighteen years old? Why or why not? (Spring semester) "Earth Day" is celebrated in the U.S. in late April. What does "Earth Day" mean to you? Our living environment (nature, natural resources, etc.) has changed a lot over the last few decades. What are some of the things people can do to protect the environment? What part of nature do you enjoy the most in your neighborhood? Describe it. Read the short poem below by Percy Bysshe Shelley, an English romantic poet in the early 19th century. Write how you feel as you read the poem. "Away, away, from men and towns, To the wild wood and the downs, To the silent wilderness, Where the soul need not repress its music."

Week 16 Click here for additional writing prompts: What has been your greatest accomplishment this semester? Describe it. What is your future academic plan? Describe it. What is your future career plan? Describe it. What advice would you give to an ESL student who is going to take this course? What advice would you give to someone who is starting college for the first time? What suggestions would you have to improve this free textbook (Building Academic Writing Skills)? (Spring semester) What are your plans for the summer? (Fall semester) What are you plans for the winter break? What do you think your life will be like in the next five years? What do you think the five ten years will bring to this world, your native country, the U.S.?

V. Links to Additional Topics

The following websites lead you to images and additional topics.

EXERCISE

Click here for links to images and additional writing prompts:
https://caroling.wordpress.com/2012/05/12/115-prompts-to-get-you-writing-your-life-story (110+ prompts for writing life stories) https://writingexercises.co.uk/index.php (hundreds of prompts. Ideas to write about through first word, first line, random images, etc.)
http://kazuo.fc2web.com/English/TOEFL-essay.htm (180+ prompts to choose from. Though those prompts are for TOEFL practice, they are just as relevant to your purpose.) You may also use images as a starting point for your writing. The following links provide interesting images:
https://www.publicdomainpictures.net/en/ https://pixabay.com/ https://www.pexels.com/ https://unsplash.com/ https://deeperlearning4all.org/images/#images
https://www.imagesofempowerment.org/collections/

The journey to good writing continues...

(Picture: sailboat on water near island)

sailboat on water near island

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